

M E Y S S A L E G A L

GCC Legal Salary & Market Guide

For lawyers



2026 edition

How to use this guide

Our aim is to provide you with an overview of current salary trends across the region. This document gives a view on base and allowances, along with some context on what is shaping packages at each level, so that you can see where you sit and what a strong package looks like.

We show each level across three positions rather than a single range, because a range tells you the floor and the ceiling and nothing about who sits where. Standard is a good, reliable lawyer at that level. Strong is someone trusted with more than the title suggests. Exceptional is the small group who are clearly operating above it. The gap between the three is usually wider than people expect.

Figures are monthly base salary in AED and exclude bonus, and in private practice equity and profit share. They come from our own placements and conversations across the UAE, so treat them as a guide rather than a quote.

Private Practice

AED PER MONTH · BASE SALARY

LEVEL	STANDARD	STRONG	EXCEPTIONAL
Managing Partner	142k–191k	176k–237k	215k–289k
Partner	103k–139k	159k–215k	188k–254k
Counsel	83k–113k	104k–141k	127k–172k
Senior Associate	45k–60k	61k–82k	72k–97k
Associate	32k–43k	49k–67k	58k–79k
Newly Qualified	25k–34k	38k–51k	45k–60k

In-House

AED PER MONTH · BASE SALARY

LEVEL	STANDARD	STRONG	EXCEPTIONAL
Chief Legal Officer	95k–128k	118k–159k	152k–204k
General Counsel	88k–119k	107k–145k	131k–177k
Senior Counsel / Deputy GC	54k–72k	66k–89k	78k–105k
Legal Counsel	35k–48k	43k–58k	51k–68k
Junior Legal Counsel	25k–34k	30k–41k	37k–50k

Compliance

AED PER MONTH · BASE SALARY

LEVEL	STANDARD	STRONG	EXCEPTIONAL
Head of Compliance / CCO	82k–110k	102k–137k	124k–167k
Director / MLRO	63k–85k	80k–107k	94k–127k
Senior Manager / VP	46k–63k	58k–79k	69k–93k
Compliance Manager	30k–40k	42k–56k	49k–66k
Senior Compliance Officer	22k–30k	27k–36k	32k–43k

The rest of the package

Base is only part of the picture in the GCC. The rest varies by employer, sector and family circumstances, but these are the pieces that usually make up an offer.

ELEMENT	WHAT TO EXPECT IN THE MARKET
Housing	Often 20 to 30 per cent of base, or a set allowance. Senior roles commonly AED 10,000 to 30,000 a month, sometimes rolled into a single all-in figure.
Transport	Around AED 2,000 to 3,500 a month, or a company car at senior level.
Flights	Annual home flights for the lawyer and immediate family, economy through to business by seniority.
Schooling	Partial to full education support at senior and family level, usually capped per child.
Medical	Family medical cover is standard across in-house and most firms.
Bonus	In-house typically 10 to 25 per cent of base, higher at GC and CLO and in financial services. Private practice partners earn through profit share; associate bonuses vary by firm.
How it is quoted	Packages come either all-in (base already includes allowances) or basic plus allowances. Always compare like for like.

Where the hiring is

A lot of the hiring is being driven by regulation. Each new rule on data, AI or financial services lands on in-house and compliance teams and, within a year or so, becomes a role. Saudi Arabia keeps growing, and the UAE funds and capital markets space, Abu Dhabi in particular, is busy. The lawyers at the top of each band are not always the strongest technicians. They are the ones with commercial judgement who can move quickly.

What this means for you

Look past the headline number to the whole package, and be honest about where you sit within a band. September to December is usually the best time of year to be in the market. And the clearer you are about what you actually want from the next role, the better the advice anyone can give you.

Speak to us



If you would like an honest view on where you sit, or what a next move could look like, we would be happy to talk. Everything stays in confidence.

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